

for your sake
I shall take

told this
a token was





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Author: Stephen Hawes

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*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK THE CÕFORTE
OF LOUERS ***

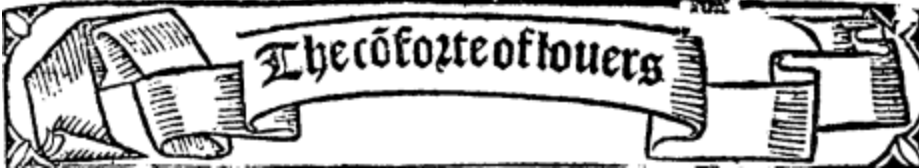
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Spelling and punctuation are unchanged; possible errors are noted with mouse-hover popups. Reconstructions are shown in *italics*. Folio numbers in *iiii-vi* were added by the transcriber. Details about abbreviations and reconstructions are given at the [end of the text](#).



The comferte of louers made and compyled by Steuen Hawes somtyme grome of the honourable chambre of our late souerayne lorde kynge Henry y^e seuenth (whose soule god pardon). In the seconde yere of the reygne of our most naturall souerayne lorde kȳge Henry the eyght.

¶ The prohemye.



He gentyll poetes / vnder cloudy fygures
Do touche a trouth / and cloke it subtylly
Harde is to cōstrue poetycall scryptures
They are so fayned / & made sētēcyously
For som do wryte of loue by fables pryuely
Some do endyte / vpon good moralyte
Of chyualrous actes / done in antyquyte

Whose fables and storyes ben pastymes pleasaunt
To lordes and ladyes / as is theyr lykyng
Dyuers to moralyte / ben oft attendaunt
And many delyte to rede of louyng
Youth loueth aduenture / pleasure and lykyng
Aege foloweth polycy / sadnesse and prudence
Thus they do dyffre / eche in experyence

I lytell or nought / experte in this scyence
Compyle suche bokes / to deuoyde ydlenes
Besechynge the reders / with all my delygence
Where as I offende / for to correct doubtles
Submyttyng me to theyr grete gentylnes
As none hystoryagraffe / nor poete laureate
But gladly wolde folowe / the makynge of Lydgate

Fyrst noble Gower / moralytees dyde endyte
And after hym Cauncers / grete bokes delectable
Lyke a good phylozophre / meruaylously dyde wryte
After them Lydgate / the monke commendable
Made many wonderfull bokes moche profytable
But syth the are deed / & theyr bodyes layde in chest
I pray to god to gyue theyr soules good rest

¶ Finis prohemii.

Whan fayre was phebus / w^t his bemes bryght
Amyddes of gemyny / aloft the fymament
Without blacke cloudes / castynge his pured lyght
With sorowe opprest / and grete incombremment
Remembrynge well / my lady excellent
Saynge o fortune helpe me to preuayle
For thou knowest all my paynfull trauayle

I went than musynge / in a medowe grene
Myselfe alone / amonge the floures in dede
With god aboue / the futertens is sene
To god I sayd / thou mayst my mater spede
And me rewarde / accordynge to my mede
Thou knowest the trouthe / I am to the true
Whan that thou lyst / thou mayst them all subdue

Who dyde preserue the yonge edyppus
Whiche sholde haue be slayne by calculacyon
To deuoyde grete thynges / the story sheweth vs

That were to come / by true reuelacyon
Takyng after theyr hole operacyon
In this edyppus / accordynge to affecte
Theyr cursed calkyng / holly to abiecte

Who dyde preserue / Ionas and moyses
Who dyde preserue yet many other mo
As the byble maketh mencyon doubles
Who dyde kepe Charles frome his euyl fo
Who was he / that euer coude do so
But god alone / than in lyke wyse maye he
Kepe me full sure / frome all inyquyte

Thus as I called to my remembraunce
Suche trewe examples / I tenderly dyde wepe
Remembryng well / goddes hyghe ordynaũce
Syghynge full oft / with inwarde teres depe
Tyll at the last / I fell in to a slepe
And in this slepe / me thought I dyde repayre
My selfe alone / in to a garden fayre

This goodly gardyn / I dyde well beholde
Where I sawe a place / ryght gaye and glorious
With golden turrets / paynted many a folde
Lyke a place of pleasure moste solacyous
The wyndowes glased / with crystall precyous
The golden fanes / with wynde and melody
By dulcet sounde / and meruaylous armony

The knottes flagraunt / with aromatyke odoure
With goodly sprynges / of meruaylous mountaynes
I dyde than tast / the redolent lycoure
Moost clere and swete / of the goodly vaynes
Whiche dyde me ease / somewhat of my paynes
Tyll to me came / a lady of goodly age
Apareyled sadly / and demure of vysage

To me she sayd / me thynke ye are not well
ye haue caught colde / and do lyue in care
Tell me your mynde / now shortly euerydele
To layne the trouthe / I charge you to beware
I shall for you / a remedy prepare
Dyspeyre you not / for no thyng that is past
Tell me your mynde / and be nought agast

Alas madame / vnto her than I sayd
It is no wonder / of myne inwarde payne
yf that my herte be meruayllously dysmayde
My trouthe and loue / therof is cause certayne
Dyuers yeres ago / I dyde in mynde retayne
A lady yonge / a lady fayre of syght
Good // wyse / and goodly / an holsome sterre of lyght

I durst not speke vnto her of my loue
Yet vnder coloure I dyuers bokes dyde make
Full pryuely / to come to my aboue
Thus many nyghtes / I watched for her sake
To her and to hers / my trouthe well to take
Without ony spotte / of ony maner yll
God knoweth all myn herte / my mynde & my wyll

The hygh dame nature / by her grete myght & power
Man / beest / and foule / in euery degre
Fro whens they came at euery maner houre
Dooth trye the trouthe / without duplycyte
For euery thyng must shewe the properte
Gentyll vngentyll / dame nature so well tryet
That all persones it openly espyeth

The lorde and knyght / delyteth for to here
Cronycles and storyes / of noble chyualry
The gentyll man gentylnes / for his passe tyme dere
The man of lawe / to here lawe truely
The yeman delyteth to talke of yomanry

The ploman his londe for to ere and sowe
Thus nature werketh / in hye degre and lowe

For yf there were one of the gentyll blode
Conuayde to yomanry for nourysshement
Dyscrecyon comen he sholde chaunge his mode
Though he knewe not / his parentes verament
Yet nature wolde werke / so by entendymment
That he sholde folowe / the condycyons doubtles
Of his true blode / by outwarde gentylnes

In all this worlde / ben but thynges twayne
As loue and hate / the trouth for to tell
And yf I sholde hate my lady certayne
Than worthy I were / to dye of deth cruell
Seynge all ladyes / that she doth excell
In beaute / grace / prudence and mekenes
What man on lyue / can more in one expres

yf she with me sholde take dyspleasure
Whiche loueth her by honoures desyre
What sholde she do / with suceh a creature
That hateth her / by inwarde fraude and yre
I yet a louer / do not so atyre
My fayth and hope / I put in her grace
Releace to graunt me / by good tyme and space

Thretened with sorowe / of may paynes grete
Thre yeres ago my ryght hande I dyde bynde
Fro my browes for fere / y^e dropes doune dyde sweet
God knoweth all it was nothyng my mynde
Vnto no persone / I durst my her to vntwynde
yet the trouthe knowynge / the good gretest P
Maye me release / of all my / p / p / p / thre

Now ryght fayre lady / so sadde and demure
My mynde ye knowe / in euery maner thyng

I trust for trouthe / ye wyll not me dyscure
Sythes I haue shewed you without lesynge
At your request / the cause of my mournynge
Whiche abyde in sorowe / in my remembraunce
Without good conforte / saufe of esperaunce

Fayre sone sayd she / sythens I knowe your thought
your worde and dede / and here to be one
Dyspayre you not / for it auayleth nought
Ioye cometh after / whan the payne is gone
Conforte yourselfe / and muse not so alone
Doubt ye no thyng / but god wyll so agre
That at the last / ye shall your lady se

Be alwaye meke / let wysdome be your guyde
Aduenture for honoure / and put your selfe in preace
Clymbe not to fast / lest sodenly ye slyde
Lete god werke styll / he wyll your mynde encrece
Begynne no warre / be gladde to kepe the peace
Prepence no thyng / agaynst the honoure
Of ony lady / by fraudulent fauoure

Alas madame / vnto her than sayd I
About .xx. woulues / dyde me touse and rent
Not longe agone / delynge moost shamefully
That by theyr tuggyng / my lyfe was nere spent
I dyde perceyue / somewhat of theyr entente
As the trouthe is knowen / vnto god aboue
My ladyes fader they dyde lytell loue

Seynge theyr falshode / and theyr subtylte
For fere of deth / where as I loued best
I dyde dysprayse / to knowe theyr cruelte
Somwhat to wysdome / accordynge to behest
Though that my body had but lytell rest
My herte was trewe vnto my ladyes blood
For all theyr dedes I thought no thyng but good

Some had wende the hous for to swepe
Nought was theyr besom / I holde it set on fyre
The inwarde wo in to my herte dyde crepe
To god aboue / I made my hole desyre
Saynge o good lorde of heuenly empyre
Let the mount with all braunches swete
Entyerly growe / god gyue vs grace to mete

Soma had wened for to haue made an ende
Of my bokes / before he hadde begynnynge
But all vayne they dyde so comprehende
Whan they of them lacke vnderstandynge
Vaynfull was & is theyr mysse contryuynge
Who lyst the trouthe of them for to enfuse
For the reed and whyte they wryte full true

Well sayd this lady I haue perceueraunce
Of our bokes / whiche that ye endyte
So as ye saye is all the cyrcumstaunce
Vnto the hyghe pleasure of the reed and the whyte
Which hath your trouth / and wyll you acquyte
Doubte ye no thyng / but at the last ye maye
Of your true mynde yet fynde a Ioyfull daye

Forsothe I sayd / dysdayne and straungenesse
I fere them sore / and fals reporte
I wolde they were / in warde all doutles
Lyke as I was / without conforte
Than wolde I thynke / my lady wolde resorte
Vnto dame mercy / my payne to consyder
God knoweth all / I wolde we were togyder

Though in meane season / of grene grasse I fede
It wolde not greue me / yf she knewe my heuynesse
My trauayle is grete / I praye god be my spede
To resyste the myght / of myn enmyes subtylnesse
Whiche awayte to take / me by theyr doublenesse

My wysdome is lytel / yet god may graunt me grace
Them to defende / in euery maner of cace

Lerne this she sayd / yf that you can by wytte
Of foes make frendes / they wyll be to you sure
yf that theyr frendshyp / be vnto you knytte
It is oft stedfast / and wyll longe endure
yf alwaye malyce / they wyll put in vre
No doubte it is / than god so hygght and stronge
Ful meruaylously / wyl soone reuenge theyr wronge

And now she sayd come on your waye with me
Unto a goodly toure whiche is solacyous
Beholde it yonder / full of felycyte
Quadrant it was / me thought full meruaylous
With golden turrets / gaye and glorious
Gargayled with greyhoũdes / and with many lyons
Made of fyne golde / with dyuers sondry dragons

The wyndowes byrall / without resplendysshant
The fayre yuery / coloured with grene
And all aboute there was dependaunt
Grete gargyles of golde / full meruaylously besene
Neuer was made / a fayrer place I wene
The ryght excellent lady toke her intresse
Ryght so dyde I / by meruaylous swetnesse

Whan we came in / I dyde aboute beholde
The goodly temple / with pynacles vp sette
Wherin were ymages / of kynges all of golde
With dyuers scryptures / without ony lette
Aloft the rooffe / were emeraudes full grette
Set in fyne golde / with amyable rudyes
Endented with dyamondes / and mayn turkyes

The wyndowes hystoried / with many noble kynges
The pyllers Iasper / dyuersed with asure

By pendaunt penacles / of many noble rynges
The pauement calcedony / beynge fayre and sure
The aras golde / with the story pure
Of the syche of thebes / with actes auenturous
Of ryght noble knyghtes / hardy and chyualrous

Than sayd this lady / I must now go hence
Passe ye tyme here / accordyng to your lykyng
It maye fortune / your lady of excellence
Wyll passe her tyme here / soone by walkyng
Than maye she se / your dolefull mournyng
And fare ye well / I maye no lenger tary
Marke well my lesson / and from it do not vary

Whan she was gone / the temple all alonge
I went my selfe / with syghtes grete and feruent
Alas I sayd / with inwarde paynes stronge
My herte doth blede / now all to torne and rent
For lacke of conforte / my herte is almost spent
O meruelo^{us} fortune / which hast ã loue me brought
Where is my conforte / that I so longe haue sought

O wonderfull loue / whiche fell vnto my lotte
O loue ryght clene / without ony thought vntrue
Syth thy fyrst louyng / not blemysed with spotte
But euermore / the falseshede to extue
O dolorous payne / whiche doste renue
O pyteous herte / where is the helthe and boote
Of thy lady / that perst the at the roote

What thyng is loue / that causeth suche turment
From whens cometh it / me thynke it is good questyõ
Yf it be nature / from nature it is sent
Loue maye come of kynde by true affeccyon
Loue may appetyte / by naturall eleccyon
Than must loue nedes be / I perceyue it in mynde
A thyng fyrst gyuen / by the god of kynde

Alas o nature / why mayst not thou truely
Cause my lady loue / as thou hast me constrayned
Hath she power to domyne the vtterly
Why mayst not thou / cause her *be* somewhat payned
With natures moeuyng / for *loue is* not fayned
Alas for sorowe / why madest thou *her* so fayre
Without to loue / that she lyst soone repayre

Two thynges me conforte / euer in pryncypall
The fyrst be bokes / made in antyquyte
By Gower and Chauncers / poetes rethorycall
And Lydgate eke / by good auctoryte
Makyng mencyon / of the felycyte
Of my lady and me / by dame fortunes chaunce
To mete togyders / by wonderfull ordynaunce

The seconde is / where fortune dooth me bryng
In many placys / I se by prophecy
As in the storyes / of the olde buyldyng
Letters for my lady / depeynted wonderly
And letters for me / besyde her meruayllously
Agreyng well / vnto my bokes all
In dyuers placys / I se it in generall

O loue moost dere / o loue nere to my harte
O gentyll floure / I wolde you knewe my wo
Now that your beaute / perst me with the darte
With your vertue / and your mekenes also
Sythens ye so dyde / it is ryght longe ago
My herte doth se you / it is for you bebledde
Myne eyen with teeres / ben often made full redde

Where are ye now / the floure of Ioye and grace
Whiche myght me conforte / in this inwarde sorowe
Myne excellent lady / it is a ryght pyteous case
Good be my guyde / and saynt George vnto borowe
O clere Aurora / the sterre of the morowe

Whiche many yeres / with thy bemes mery
Hath me awaked / to se thyne emyspery

Thus as I mourned / I sawe than appere
Thre goodly myrours dependaunt on the wall
Set in fyne golde bordred with stones clere
The glasses pure / they were of crystall
Made longe ago to be memoryall
And vnder the fyrst glasse ryght fayre wryten was
Beholde thy selfe / and thy fautes or thou passe

By a sylken threde / small as ony heere
Ouer I sawe hange / a swerde full ponderous
Without a scauberde / full sharpe for to fere
The poynt dounwarde / ryght harde and asperous
All this I sawe / with hert full dolorous
Yet at auenture / to se the mystery
In the myroure / I loked than full sodenly

In this glasse I sawe / how I had ledde my lyfe
Sythens the tyme of my dyscrecyon
As vnto wyldnesse / alwaye affyrmatyfe
Folowyng the pleasure / of wylfull amonycyon
Not vnto vertue hauynge intencyon
Ihesu sayd I / thou hast me well preserued
From this swerdes fall / whiche I haue oft deserued

O ye estates / aloft on fortunes whele
Remembre this swerde / whiche ouer you dependeth
Beware the fall / before that ye it fele
Se your one euyll / se what vengeaunce ensueth
Correcte none other / whan that your fautes renueth
Calke not not goddes power / bryef not y^e tens future
Beholde this glasse / se how he may endure

Many one *weneth* / *the future tens to brefe*
By calculacyon goddes power to withstande

Bathynge theyr swerdes / in blode by myschefe
Tyll at the last as I do vnderstande
This swerde doth fal by the myght of goddes hande
Vpon then all / whiche wolde his power abate
Then they repent but than it is to late

This goodly myrour / I ryght well behelde
Remembrynge well / my dedes done in tymes past
I toke forwytt / than for to be my shelde
By grace well armed / not to be agast
Thus as I stode / I dyde se at the last
The seconde myrour / as bryght as phebus
Set rounde about / with stones precyous

Ouer whiche dyde hãge / a floure of golde ryght fyne
Wherin was set / an emeraude full bryght
Ryght large and grete / whiche wõderfull dyde shyne
That me thought it was / grete conforte to my syght
Bordred with dyamondes / castyge a meruaylo^{us} lyght
This floure dyde hange / by a ryght subtyll gynne
With a chayne of yron / and many a pryue pynne

Besyde whiche there was / a table of golde
With a goodly scrypture / enameled of grene
The sentence wherof / I dyde well beholde
The whiche sayd thus / it is openly sene
That many a one / full pryuely dooth wene
To blynde an other / by crafte and subtylnes
That ofte blyndeth hym / for all his doublenes

In this myrour whiche is here besyde
Thou shalt well lerne / they selfe for to knowe
Passe forth no ferder / but loke and abyde
Se what shall come / lest that thou ouer throwe
A sodayne rysynge dooth oft fall alowe
Without the grounde / be ryghe sure and perfyte
Beholde well this glasse / & take thy respyte

Whan thou hast so done / to this floure resorte
Laboure to gete it / from this harde yren chayne
Unto the gynnes / vnto thy grete conforte
Yf that thou canst / and take it for thy payne
To be they helpe / in thy Iournaye certayne
Lo here the vertues vnder wryten be
Of this ryall floure in euery degre

This ryche emeraude / who so dooth it bere
From his fyrst werynge / his syght shal not mynysshe
Payne of the heed he nedeth not to fere
By dynt of swerde / he shall neuer perysshe
Ne no thyng begyn / but he shall well fynysse
Yf it be ryghtfull aftyr a true entent
Without resystence of grete impedymment

Of all nygromancy / and fals enchauntement
Agaynst hym wrought / he shall knowe the effecte
They can not blynde hym by cursed sentement
But he theyr werkes may ryght soone abiecte
No maner poyson he nedeth to susspecte
Neyther in mete not yet in ale ne wyne
Yf it beset well besyde a serpentyne

Yf he vntrue be vnto his gentyll lady
It wyll breke asondre / or crase than doubtlesse
It kepeth close / neuēt the auoutry
This gentyll emeraude / this stone of rychesse
Hath many mo vertues / whiche I do not expresse
As saynt Iohan euangelyst doeth shewe openly
Who of his makynge lyst se the lapydary

When I had aduerted / in my remembraunce
All the maters / vnto the glasse I wente
Beholdynge it / by a longe cyrcumstaunce
Where as I dyde perceyue well verament
How preuy malyce / his messengers had sent

With subtyll engynes / to lye in a wayte
Yf that they coude take me with a bayte

I sawe there trappes / I sawe theyr gynnes all
I thanked god than / the swete holy goost
Whiche brought me hyder so well in specyall
Without whiche myrour / I had been but loost
In god aboue / the lorde of myghtes moost
I put my trust / for to withstande theyr euyl
Whiche dayly wrought / by the myght of the deuyll

I sawe theyr maysters blacke and tydyous
Made by the craft of many a nacyon
For to dystroye me / with strokes peryllous
To lette my Iournaye / as I make relacyon
Peryllous was the waye / and the cytuacyon
Full gladde was I of the vertu of this glasse
Whiche shewed me / what daungers I sholde passe

O all ye estates / of the hygh renowne
Beware these gynnes / beware theyr subtylte
The deuyll is grete / *and* *re*dy to cast downe
By calculacyon / of the *cursed* cruelte
Of the subtyll beestes / full of inyquyte
In the olde tyme what snares were there sette
By fals calkyng / to dystroye lordes grete

Than after this to the yron gynne
I wente anone my wyte for to proue
By lytell and lytell / to vndo euery pynne
Thus in and out / I dyde the chayne ofte moue
Yet coude I not come / vnto myne aboue
Tyll at the last / I dyde the crafte espy
Vndoyng the pynnes / & chayne full meruaylously

Full gladde was I than / whan I had this floure
I kyst it oft / I behelde the coloure grene

It swaged ryght well / myn inwarde doloure
Myn eyes confortd / with the bryghtnes I wene
This ryall floure / this emeraude to shene
Whan I had goten it by my prudence
Ryght gladde I was / of fortunes premynence

O fortune sayd I / thou art ryght fauorable
For many a one / hath ben by symylytude
To wynne this floure / full gretely tendable
But they the subtylnes / myght nothyng exclude
Sythnen by wysdome / I dyde this fraude conclude
This floure / I sette nere my harte
For perfyte loue / of my fayre ladyes darte

So this accomplysshed / than incontynent
To the thynde myrour I went dyrectly
Beholdyng aboute by good auysement
Seynge an ymage made full wonderly
Of the holy goost with flambes ardauntly
Vnder whiche I sawe with letters fayre and pure
In golde well grauen this meruaylous scrypture

Frome the fader and the sone my power procedyng
And of my selfe I god do ryght ofte inspyre
Dyuers creatures with spyrytuall knowyng
Inuysyble by dyuyne flambyng fyre
The eyes I entre not it is not my desyre
& am not coloured of the terrestryall ground
Nor entre the eres for I do not sounde

Nor by the nose for I am not myxte
With ony maner of the ayry influence
Nor by the mouthe for I am not fyxte
For to be swallowed by erthly experyence
Nor yet by felyng or touchyng exystence
My power dyuyne can not be palpable
For I myselfe am no thyng manyable

Yet vysyble I may be by good apparaunce
As in the lykenesse of a doue vnto chryste Ihesu
At his baptysme I dyde it with good countenaunce
To shewe our godhed to be hygh and true
And at his transfiguracyon our power to ensue
In a fayre cloude with clere rayes radyaunt
Ouer hym that I was well apparaunt

Also truely yet at the feest of pentycoste
To the sones moder and the apostelles all
In tonges of fyre as god of myghtes moost
I dyde appere shewynge my power spyrytuall
Enflambynge theyr hertes by vertues supernall
Whiche after that by languages well
In euery regyon coude pronounce the gospell

And where I lyst by power dyuyne
I do enspyre oft causynge grete prophecy
Whiche is misconstrued whan some do enclyne
Thynkyng by theyr wytte to perceyue it lyghtly
Or elles calke with deuylls the trouth to sertyfy
Whiche contrary be to all true saynge
For deuylls be subtyll and alwaye lyenge

Whan I had aduerted with my dylygence
All the scrypture I sawe me besyde
Hãge a fayre swerde & shelde of meruailous excellẽce
Whiche to beholde I dyde than abyde
To blase the armes I dyde well prouyde
The felde was syluer / and in it a medowe grene
With an olyue tre full meruaylously besene

Two lyons of asure vpon euery syde
Couchande were truely besyde this olyue tree
A hande of stele wherin was wryten pryde
Dyde holde this ryall swerde in certaynte
A scrypture there was whiche sayd by subtylte

Of a grete lady hondred yeres ago
In the hande of stele this swerde was closed so

No maner persone / mayes *touch*e this swerde
But one persone / chosen by *god* in dede
Of this ladyes kynred / *not* to be aferde
To touche this hande / his mater for to spede
And to vndo it / and take it for his mede
But yf that he / be not of the lygnage
The hand wyll sle hym / after olde vsage

This ryall swerde / that called is preprudence
Who can it gette / it hath these vertues thre
Fyrst to wynne ryght / without longe resystence
Secondly encreaseth / all trouth and amyte
Thyrldy of the berer through duplycyte
Be pryuely fals / to the ordre of chyualry
The swerdes crosse wyll crase / and shewe it openly

This shelde also / who so dooth it bere
Whiche of olde tyme / was called perceueraunce
Hath thre vertues / fyrst he nedeth not fere
Ony grete blodeshede / by wronge incombraunce
Secondly / it wolde make good apparaunce
By hete vnto hym / to gyue hym warnynge
To be redy / agayst his enmyes comynge

The thynde is this / yf this calenge be ryghtfull
Neuer no swerde / shall through his harneys perce
Nor make hym blody / with woundes rufull
For he there strength / may ryghtfully reuerce
Yet moreouer / as I do well reherce
This ryall shelde / in what place it be borne
Shall soone be wonne / and shall not be forlorne

These thynges sene / to the thynde myroure clere
I went anone / and in it loked ryght ofte

Where in my syght / dyde wonderly appere
The firmament / with the sonne all alofte
The wynde not grete / but blowynge fayre and softe
And besyde the sonne / I sawe a meruaylous sterre
With beames twayne / the whiche were cast aferre

The one turnynge towarde the sterre agayne
The other stretched ryght towarde Phebus
To beholde this sterre / I was somewhat fayne
But than I mused with herte full dolorous
Whyder it sygnyfyed thynges good or peryllous
Thus longe I studyed / tyll at the last I thought
What it sholde meane / as in my herte I sought

This sterre it sygnyfyeth the resynge of a knyght
The bowynge beame agayne so tournynge
Betokened rattonnes of them whiche by myght
Wolde hym resyst by theyr wronge resystynge
The beame towarde Phebus clerely shynynge
Betokened many meruaylous fyres grete
On them to lyght that wolde his purpose lete

In the fyre clerest of euery element
God hath appered vnto many a one
Inspyrynge them / with grete wytte refulgent
Who lyst to rede many dayes agone
Many one wryteth trouthe / yet cōforte hath he none
Wherefore I fere me / lyke a swarme of bees
Wylde fyre wyll lyght amonge a thousande pees

¶ Sepe expugnauerunt me a iuuentute mea: et enim non potuerunt michi.

As the cantycles maketh good mencyon
They haue oft expugned me / syth my yonge age
Yet coude they haue me / in theyr domynyon
Though many a one / vnhappely do rage
They shall haue sorowe that shytted me in a cage
In a grete dyspyte of the holy goost

He maye them brenne / theyr calkyng is but loost

¶ Supra dorsum meū fabricauerūt peccatores: prolongauerūt iniquitatē suā.

Vpon my backe synners hath fabrysed
They haue prolonged theyr grete inyquyte
From daye to daye it is not my mynysshed
Wherfore for vengeance by grete extremyte
It cryeth aboue / now vnto the deyte
Whiche that his mynysters haue suffred so longe
To lyue in synne and euyll wayes wronge

Whan I had perceyued euery maner thyng
Of this ryall myroure / accordyng to effecte
Remembryng the verses / of the olde sayng
Whiche in my mynde I dyde well coniecte
Than to the swerde / I thought to haue respecte
Ryght so I went / than at all auenture
Vnto the hande / that helde the swerde so sure

I felte the hande / of the stell so fyne
Me thought it quaked / the fyngers gan to stretch
I thought by that / I came than of the lyne
Of the grete lady / that fyrst the swerde dyde fetch
The swerdes pomell / I began to ketch
The hande swerued / but yet neuer the lesse
I helde them bothe / by excellent prowes

And at the last / I felte the hande departe
The swerde I toke / with all my besynesse
So I subdued / all the magykes arte
And founde the scauberde / of meruaylous rychesse
After that I toke the shelde doune doubtlesse
Kyssyng the swerde / and the shelde ofte I wys
Thankyng god / the whiche was cause of this

Gladde was I than / of my ryall floure
Of my swerde and shelde / I reioyced also

It pacyfied well / my inwarde doloure
But fro my ladies beaute / my mynde myght not go
I loued her surely / for I loued no mo
Thus my fayre floure / and my swerde and shelde
With eyen ryght meke / full often I behelde

Than sayd I (well) this is an happy chaunce
I trust now shortly / my lady for to se
O fortune sayd I / whiche brought me on the daũce
Fyrst to beholde her ryght excellent beaute
And so by chaunce / hast hyder conueyde me
Getynge me also / my floure my shelde and swerde
I nought mystrust the / why sholde I be aferde

O ryght fayre lady / as the bryght daye sterre
Shyneth before the rysynge of the sonne
Castynge her beames / all aboute aferre
Exylynge grete wyndes / and the mystes donne
So ryght fayre lady / where as thou doost wonne
Thy beautefull bryghtnes / thy vertue and thy grace
Dooth clere Illumyne / all thy boure and place

The gentyll *herte is plunged in dystresse*
Dooth walowe and tomble in somers nyght
Replete with wo / and mortall heuynesse
Tyll that aurora / with her beames bryght
Aboute the fymament / castynge her pured lyght
Ageynst the rysynge / of refulgent tytan
Whan that declyneth / the fayre dame dyan

Than dooth the louer / out of this bedde aryse
With wofull mynde / beholdynge than the ayre
Alas he sayth / what nedeth to deuyse
Ony suche pastyme / here for to repayre
Where is my conforte / where is my lady fayre
Where is my Ioye / where is now all my boote
Where is she nowe / that persed my herte rote

This maye I saye / vnto my owne dere loue
My goodly lady / fayrest and moost swete
In all my bokes / fayre fortune doth moue
For a place of grace / where that we sholde mete
Also my bokes full pryuely you grete
The effectes therof / dooth well dayly ensue
By meruelous thynges / to proue them to be true

The more my payne / the more my loue encreaseth
The more my leopardy / the truer is my harte
The more I suffre / the lesse the fyre releaseth
The more I complayne the more is my smarte
The more I se her / the sharper is the darte
The more I wryte / the more my teeres dystyll
The more I loue / the hotter is my wyll

O moost fayre lady / yonge / good / and vertuous
I knewe full well / neuer your countenaunce
Shewed me ony token / to make me amerous
But what for that / your prudent gouernaunce
Hath enrached my herte / for to gyue attendaunce
your excellent beaute / you coude no thyng lette
To cause my herte vpon you to be sette

My ryght fayre lady / yf at the chesse I drawe
My selfe I knowe not / as a cheke frome a mate
But god aboute the whiche sholde haue in awe
By drede truely euery true estate
He maye take vengeaunce / though he tary late
He knoweth my mynde / he knoweth my remedy
He maye reuenge me / he knoweth my leoperdy

O thou fayre fortune / torne not fro me thy face
Remembre my sorowe / for my goodly lady
My tendre herte / she dooth full oft embrace
And as of that it is no wonder why
For vpon her is all my desteny

Submyttynge me / vnto her gracyous wyll
Me for to saue or sodaynly to spyll

O ryght fayre lady of grene flouryng age
you can not do but as your frendes agre
your wyte is grete / you mekenes / dooth not swage
Exyle dysdayne / and be ruled by pety
The frenshe man sayth / that shall be shall be
yf that I dye / louer was neuer none
Deyed in this worlde / for a fayrer persone

Your Beaute causeth all my amyte
Why sholde your Beaute / to my dethe condyscende
your vertue and mekenes / dyde so arest me
Why sholde ye than to dame dysdayne intende
your prudence your goodnes / dooth mercy extende
Why sholde ye than enclyne to cruelte
Your grace I trust wyll non extremyte

A dere herte I maye complayne ryght longe
you here me not / nor se me not arayed
Nor causes my paynes for to be stronge
It was myn eyes / that made me fyrst dysmayde
With stroke of loue / that coude not me delaye
My ryght fayre lady / my herte is colde and faynt
Wolde now to god / that you knewe my complaynte

Thus as I mourned I herde a lady speke
I loked asyde I sawe my lady gracyous
My herte than fared / as it sholde breke
For perfyte Ioye whiche was solacyous
Before her grace / ryght swete and precyous
I kneled doune / saynge with all mekenesse
Please it your grace / & excellent noblenes

No dyspleasure to take for my beyng here
For fortune me brought / to this place ryall

Where I haue wonne this floure so vertuous & dere
This swerde and shelde / also not peregall
Towadre hym aduenture to be tryumphall
And now by fortunes desteny and fate
Do here my duety vnto your hygh estate

Ihesu sayd she than / who hadde wende to fynde
Your selfe walkynge / in this place all alone
Full lytell thought I / ye were not in my mynde
What is the cause / that ye make suche mone
I thynke some thyng / be from you past and gone
But I wonder / how that ye dyde attayne
This floure / this swerde / the shelde also certayne

For by a lady in the antyquyte
They were made to a meruaylous entente
That none sholde get them / but by auctoryte
Whiche onely by fortune / sholde hyder be sent
Full many knyghtes by entendement
Hath them aduentred / to haue them in dede
But all was vayne / for they myght neuer spede

Wherefore surely / ye are moche fortunate
Them for to wyne by your aduenture
But it was no thyng to you ordynate
And you dyde well / to put your selfe in vre
To proue the leoperdy / whiche hath made you sure
Leue all your mournynge / for there is no wyght
Hath greter cause / for to be gladde and lyght

I behelde well her demure countenaunce
Vnto her swete wordes / gyuyng good audyence
And than I marked in my remembraunce
Her pleasaunt apparayle / with all my dylygence
Whiche was full ryche of meruaylous excellence
Fyrst alofte her forheed / full properly was dressed
Vnder her orellettes / her golden heere well tressed

About her necke whyte as ony lyly
A prety chayne of the fynest golde
Some lynkes with grene enameled truely
And some were blacke / the whiche I dyde beholde
The vaynes blewe / in her fayre necke well tolde
With her swete vysage tydynges to my herte
That sodynly my thoughtes were asterte

Her gowne was golde / of the clothe of tyssewe
With armyns poudred / and wyde sleues pendaunt
Her kyrtell grene of the fyne satyn newe
To bere her longe trayne / was well attendaunt
Gentyll dame dylygence / neuer varyaunt
Than as touchynge her noble stature
I thynke there can be / no goodlyer creature

As of her aege / so tendre and grene
Fayre / gracyous / prudent / and louynge humylyte
Her vertue shyneth / beynge bryght and shene
In her is nether pryde ne sybtylte
Her gentyll herte / enclyneth to bounte
Thus beaute / godlynesse / vertue / grace / and wytte
With bounte and mekenesse / in this lady is knytte

¶ Amour.

Thus whan my eyes hadde beholde her wele
Madame I sayd how may I now be gladde
But sygh and sorowe with herte euery dele
Longe haue I loued / and lytell conforte hadde
Wherfore no wonder though that I be sadde
Your tendre age / full lytell knoweth ywys
To loue vnloved / what wofull payne it is

¶ Pucell.

Thoughe that I be yonge / yet I haue perceueraũce
That ther is no lady / yf that she gentyll be
And ye haue with her ony acquayntaunce

And after cast / to her your amyte
Grounded on honoure / without duplycyte
I wolde thynke in mynde / she wolde condescende
To graunt your fauoure / yf ye none yll intende

¶ Amour.

A fayre lady I haue vnto her spoken
That I loue best / and she dooth not it knowe
Though vnto her / I haue my mynde broken
Her beaute clere / dooth my herte ouerthrowe
Whan I do se her / my herte booth sobbe I trowe
Wherefore fayre lady / all dysparate of conforte
I speke vnknownen / I must to wo resorte

¶ Pucell.

Me thynke ye speke / now vnder parable
Do ye se her here / whiche is cause of your grefe
Yf ye so dyde / that sholde I be able
As in this cause / te be to your relefe
Ryght lothe I were to se your myschefe
For ye knowe well / what case that I am yn
Peryllous it wolde be / or that ye coude me wyne

¶ Amour.

Madame sayd I / thoughe myn eyes se her not
Made dymme w^t wepynde / & with grete wo togyder
Yet dooth myn herte / at this tyme I wote
Her excellent beaute / ryght inwardly concyder
Good fortune I trust / hath now brought me hyder
To se your mekenes / whiche doth her rapyre
Whose swete conforte / dooth kepe me fro dyspayre.

¶ Pucell.

Of late I sawe a boke of your makynge
Called the pastyme of pleasure / whiche is wõderous
For I thynge and you had not ben in louynge

Ye coude neuer haue made it so sentencyous
I redde there all your passage daungerous
Wherfore I wene for the fayre ladies sake
That ye dyd loue / ye dyde that boke so make

¶ Amour.

Forsothe madame / I dyde compyle that boke
As the holy goost / I call vnto wytnes
But ygnorauntly / who so lyst to loke
Many meruelous thynges in it / I do expresse
My lyue and loue / to enserche well doublesse
Many a one doth wryte / I knowe not what in dede
Yet the effecte dooth folowe / the trouthe for to spede

¶ Pucell.

I graunt you well / all that whiche you saye
But tell me who it is / that ye loue so sure
I promyse you that I wyll not bewraye
Her name truely to ony creature
Pyte it is / you sholde suche wo endure
I do perceyue / she is not ryght ferre hence
Whiche that ye loue / withouten neclygence

¶ Amour.

Surely madame / syth it pleaseth your hyghnesse
And your honour to speke so nobly
It is your grace / that hath the intresse
In my true herte / with loue so feruently
Ryght longe ago / your beaute sodanly
Entred my mynde / and hath not syth dekyde
With feruent loue / moost wofully arayde

¶ Pucell.

And is it I / that is cause of your loue
yf it so be I can not helpe your payne
It sholde be harde / to gete to your aboue

Me for to loue / I dyde not you constrayne
ye knowe what I am / I knowe not you certayne
I am as past your loue to specyfy
Why wyll ye loue where is no remedy

¶ Amour.

A madame you are cause of my languysse
ye maye me helpe / yf that it to you please
To haue my purpose / my herte dooth not menysshe
Thoughe I was seke / ye knewe not my dysease
I am not hole / your mercy maye me ease
To proue what I am / the holy goost werke styll
My lyfe and deth / I yelde nowe to your wyll

¶ Pucell.

Fortune me thynke / is meruaylous fauorable
To you by getynge / of this ryall floure
Hauynge this swerde / and shelde so profytable
In mortall daungers / to be your socoure
But as touchynge your loue and fauoure
I can not graunt / neyther fyrst ne last
ye knowe what I am / ye knowe my loue is past

¶ Amour.

Madame the floure / the swerde and shelde also
Whiche fortune gate me / are not halfe so dere
As your persone the cause of my wo
Whose grace and beaute / shyneth so ryght clere
That in my herte your beaute doth appere
Nothyng is past / but that fortunes pleasure
May call it agayne / in the tyme future

¶ Pucell.

I denye not but that your dedes do shewe
By meruaylous prowes / truely your gentylnesse
To make you a carter / there were not afewe

But tho by crafte / whiche thought you to oppresse
To accombre them selfe applye the besynesse
yet thynke not you / so soone to se a cradle
I graunt you loue / whan ye were golden sadle

¶ Amour.

Madame truely / it is oft dayly sene
Many a one dooth trust / his fortune to take
From an other man / to make hym blynde I wene
Whiche blyndeth hym / and dooth his pompe aslake
Often some hye / do fall alowe and quake
Ryght so maye they / whiche dyde fyrst prepenche
My wo and payne for all theyr yll scyence

¶ Pucell.

To loue me so / whiche knoweth my persone
And my frendes eke / me thynke ye are not wyse
As now of me conforte haue ye none
Wherefore this answere / maye to you suffyse
I can not do / but as my frendes deuyse
I can no thyng do / but as they accorde
They haue me promest / to a myghty lorde

¶ Amour.

Madame in this worlde ben but thynges twayne
As loue and hate / ye knowe your selfe the trouthe
yf I sholde hate you / deth I were worthy playne
Than had you cause / with me to be wrothe
To deserue dyspleasure / my herte wolde be lothe
Wherfore fayre lady / I yelde at this hower
To your mekenes / my herte my loue and power

¶ Pucell.

I thynke you past all chylde ygnoraunce
But gladde I am / yf prudence be your guyde
Grace cometh often after gouernaunce

Beware of foly / beware of inwarde pryde
Clymbe not to fast / but yet fortune abyde
For your loue I thanke you / yf trouthe haue it fyxte
As with yll thought / neuer for to be myxte

¶ Amour.

Surely my mynde / nor yet my purpose
In ony cause by foly dyde vary
Neuer doynge thynke open ne close
That to your honour sholde be contrary
As yet for grace I am content to tary
For myn enmyes fraude and subtylnes
Whiche pryuely begyne theyr owne vnhapynesse

¶ Pucell.

Now of trouthe / I do vnto you tell
The thyng y^t to your enmyes is moost dyspleasure
Is for to gouerne you by wysdome ryght well
That causeth enuy in theyr hertes to endure
But be ye pacyent and ye shall be sure
Suche thynges as the ordayne vnto your gref
Wyll lyght on them to theyr owne myschefe

¶ Amour.

Surely I thynke / I suffred well the phyppe
The nette also dydde teche me on the waye
But me to bere I trowe they lost a lyppe
For the lyfte hande extendyd my Iournaye
And not to call me for my sporte and playe
Wherfore by foly yf that they do synne
The holy goost maye well the batayle wynne

¶ Pucell.

Yf fortune wolde / for the payne ye haue taken
I wolde graūt you loue / but it may nothÿge auayle
My loue is past / it can not be forsaken

Therefore I praye you leue your trauayle
Full lothe I were / your deth to bewayle
There is no nette / nor no tempted snare
But ye them knowe / wherfore ye maye beware

¶ Amour.

The snares and nettes / set in sondrye maner
Doone in tyme past / made many a byrde a dawne
The tempted gynnes / were sette so cyrculer
But euermore it is an olde sayd sawe
Examples past dooth theche one to withdrawe
Frome all suche perylles / wherfore than maye I
By grace of god / beware full parfytylly

¶ Pucell.

Ye saye the trouthe / and I do not submytte
My wyll and thought to the lady Venus
As she is goddesse / and doth true loue knytte
Ryght so to determyne / the mater betwene vs
With assent of fortune / so good gracyous
Besechynge you now for to holde you styll
For these two ladyes / maye your mynde fulfill

¶ Amour.

My ryght dere lady / I do therto consente
Swete are your wordes they confort my thought
Of Venus and fortune / I abyde the Iugement
But ryght dere lady / whome I longe haue sought
Forgete me not / remembre loue dere bought
Of my herte / I wolde ye knewe the preuyte
Than as I thynke ye wolde remembre me

* * * *

. . . . *that* came ladyes . . *yght*
. . . . she our talkynge / þ^t tyme dyde surrendre
. . . . *madame* / ye do well here repayre

To that goodly temple / for to take the ayre
With that sodaynly / I truely awoke
Takyng pen and ynke to make this lytell boke

¶ Go lytell treaty se submyte the humbly
To euery lady / excusynge thy neclygence
Besechynge them / to remembre truely
How thou doost purpose to do thy dylygence
To make suche bokes by true experyence
From daye to daye theyr pastyme to attende
Rather to dye / than thau wolde them offende

¶ Enprynted
by me Wynkyn de
Worde.



About the Text

Abbreviations are shown as superscripts. The word shown as **y^e** was printed with the **e** directly above the **y**: **y̅**. Not all browsers can display this form correctly. Abbreviations in ^t (*what, that*) were similarly written; note that the second occurrence of **p^t** uses true thorn, not the more common **y**. The “-us” abbreviation, similar to a small ⁹, is shown here as ^{us}. In verse, abbreviations were used only when a long line had to be shortened to fit the width of the page.

Damaged Words were reconstructed based on surviving parts of letters. Some reconstructions are more secure than others.

Page A.vi.

cause her be somwhat payned
for loue is not fapned
why madest thou her so fayre

Page B.i.

Thus as I mourned / I lathe than appete

Page B.i.verso

The word “tens” was used in the text because it occurs elsewhere in conjunction with “future”.

Many one weneth / the future tens to brete

Other possible pairs: **te te te te**

Page B.iii.

/and tedy to cast downe
/of the curled cruelte

Page B.iii.verso

The words “mayes touche” are not completely satisfactory, but the text demands a word-final **s**.

/mapestouche this swerde
/chosen by god in dede
/not to be aferde

Page B.vi.

And at the last/

Page B.vi.verso

The gentyll herte is plunged in dyscreffe

Page C.ii.

Hert pleasaunt apparayle/with all my dyligence
Whiche was full ryche of meruaylous excellence
Fyrst alofte her forheed/full properly was dressed
Under her ozellettes/her golden heere well tressed

Page C.iii.

Thoughe that I be yonge/
That ther is no lady/
And ye haue with her

Page C.iii.verso

Note the ð abbreviation, indicating that the line spanned the full width of the page.

pleasure/whiche is wōderous
had not ben in lounge
made it so sentencyous

Page C.iiii.

And is it I/
yf it so be I can not
It sholde be harde/
We for to loue/
ye knowe what I am/

Page C.v.

I thynke you past
But gladde, I am/
Grace cometh often
Beware of folp/

Page C.v.verso

The complete line was compared against long lines from other pages to make sure the length was not excessive.

but it may nothþge auayle

Page C.vi.

Much of this is obviously conjectural. The likeliest endings for the first two lines are "tendre" and "fayre".

~~the shal be myghty/ the shal be myghty/ the shal be myghty/~~
that came ladyes yote
the our talkynge/ þ tyme byde surrendre
madame/ye do well here repayre
To that goodly temple/for to take the ayre
With that sodaynly/ I truely awoke
Takynge pen and ynke to make this lytell boke

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